the next ball and Sehwag scored a boundary off the final delivery. Shoaib Akhtar bowled the second over and in many ways it turned out to be the defining over of the match. His first ball to me was a wide. The next ball I played watchfully. I scored a single off the third ball and then he bowled another wide to Sehwag, which also allowed us to go through for a single. It was his sixth ball that allowed me to go after him. It was short and wide. I sighted the ball early and within a fraction of a second had made up my mind to go over third man. It wasn't exactly the upper cut but more of a hard slash over the third-man fielder that sailed over the boundary. Trying to compensate for the short ball, Shoaib bowled the next one on a length on the off stump and I shuffled across and flicked him behind square for four.

It was a dream start. We had shed our initial inhibition and had started to attack. Having already scored 10 off his last two balls, I was intent on playing the final ball of the over cautiously, so I just punched it back towards mid on. It was a defensive stroke, but the timing was such that it sped across the turf to the long-on boundary. We had scored 18 off the over.

Pakistan were obviously feeling the pressure when Waqar came on to bowl in the fourth over, giving Shoaib a break after one disastrous over. Sehwag launched Waqar's first ball for six over third man and we attacked him straight away. We were now egging each other on and were speaking to each other loudly in Hindi, which the Pakistanis could understand, of course. Our body language had turned aggressive and when I finished off the Waqar over with another four we were firmly in control. We had not allowed the bowlers to settle down and had seized the advantage. It was the best early assault against Pakistan that I had been involved in and it could not have come at a more important time. We reached 50 in just five overs and the target of 273 was no longer the huge mountain it had seemed at the start of our innings.

As with most India–Pakistan matches, however, there had to be a shift in momentum and against the run of play Pakistan picked up two wickets in Waqar's next over – first Sehwag and then Sourav with the very next ball. Pakistan were back in the match. Mohammad Kaif came in next and it was important for us to put together a partnership and also not to get bogged down. Kaif played well and ran hard between the wickets to make sure I had as much of the strike as possible. The run rate had not